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Summary By: Jo Anderson | Original Study By: Anderson, J. (2018) | Published: November 21, 2018

ESTIMATED READING TIME: 6 MINUTES

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FULL TEXT EXCLUSIVE EXTERNAL STUDY

Faunalytics tested whether referring to meat by the animal it came from would have an immediate effect on attitudes or reported consumption.

Many animal advocates have discussed the implications of referring to animals and animal fle euphemisms like *beef, pork,* and *livestock*, rather than explicitly as *cow meat, pig meat,* and a

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Joan Dunayer and Melanie Joy have written extensively on the topic of speciesist language and, as "linguistic deception" via euphemism.

This perspective is supported by research. **Euphemisms allow people to distance themselves from where their food comes from, and unpleasant feelings associated with that.** And research has sho the terms "cow" and "pig" on a menu instead of "beef" and "pork" increased empathy and disgust a willingness to eat meat. They found similar results for describing cows as being "slaughtered" or "ki euphemism "harvested." People who read the euphemism felt less empathy for the cows.

We at Faunalytics wondered how far this effect would go. In part to see if just referring to animal m could have an immediate effect on attitudes (which could be good), and in part because we though term might affect study results (which could be bad if different studies use different terms). We rar randomized controlled trials (RCTs) to look at this question.

The Studies In Brief

More details at the bottom of the post.

In both RCTs, participants were randomly assigned to one of two wording conditions: standard (eu wording or alternative (explicit) wording. The two studies used different question types, but in both **assigned to standard wording were asked about their consumption of "pork" and "beef" while p assigned to explicit wording were asked about "pig" and "cow."**

In the first study, after the diet question with one of the two wordings, participants were then askec extent of their agreement or disagreement with the statement, "It is important to me that animals u well cared for."

In the second study, the follow-up agreement question used the statement: "Farm animals deserve consideration as pets and other animals, even if it means that meat costs more."

In both cases, **we hypothesized that participants in the explicit wording condition (vs. the standa condition) would report eating less beef/cow and pork/pig and express more agreement with th welfare statement.**

Results

To our surprise, those hypotheses were not supported in either study. **None of our pre-registered a showed significant differences between the euphemistic and explicit wording.** In other words:

- In Study 1, the percentage of people who said they had eaten *beef* or *pork* in the past year was from the percentage who said they had eaten *cow* or *pig*;
- In Study 2, participants' reported frequency of consumption did not differ based on whether th about their frequency of consuming *beef* and *pork* or *cow meat* and *pig meat*;
- In Study 1, the average response to the statement "It is important to me that animals used for fo cared for" did not differ based on whether people had seen the standard euphemisms or the ex

- In Study 2, the average response to the statement "Farm animals deserve the same considerati other animals, even if it means that meat costs more" also did not differ.

Implications

Based on these findings, we would caution that **word choice in many typical advocacy contexts m symbolically important than strongly influential.** Although previous research showed that using ex at the moment of food choice can influence that choice, these studies suggest that it may not have on attitudes outside of that context.

So an advocate's choice of *pig* versus *pork* may not add much oomph to their argument. Even still, mean that you shouldn't use accurate terminology that provides a subtle reminder of where meat c please do! **It is possible that repeated use might have a noticeable effect.** These studies don't adc

It would be ideal if referring to animal flesh by its explicit name even once would make people feel i more pro-animal—and to be honest, we thought it would, even if in only a small way. Unfortunately, evidence that that is the case.

As with any intervention, chances are that the more strongly the meat-animal connection is made a matters, the stronger its effect on attitudes and behavior (at least to a point—be mindful of reactan were conducted in the context of survey wording, which is important because of its prevalence in a research. To researchers, it should be reassuring that differences in terminology on surveys are unlik bias.

How Confident Can We Be In These Results?

Number of Participants

We powered these studies to be able to detect a small difference (d = 0.2; w = 0.1; f^2 = 0.02) at the level. In lay terms, that means that there's a 20% chance that each study *individually* could be wron there's no difference between standard euphemisms and explicit language, just due to random chai the probability of *both* studies being wrong is only 4%, so we can be quite confident that random c blame.

Specific Questions

We really thought that there would be a difference between the standard euphemisms and explicit the first study didn't show significant differences, we thought it might be something about the spec we used. That's why we ran the second study.

In particular, we thought that the agreement statement from Study 1 may have been affected by a c (most people tending to agree whether they've just read explicit terms for animal meat or not). We that the categorical consumption measure (have eaten or not over the past year) might be too stra be impacted by any discomfort caused by the explicit terms.

Because of those concerns, Study 2 used a more nuanced agreement statement that wouldn't pull as strongly and measured responses to it on a 7-point scale rather than a 5-point scale. It also used

consumption frequency rather than a checklist. As described above, even with those changes, there difference between conditions.

Sample Quality

These studies were conducted on Mechanical Turk, which may concern some readers given recent p bots or study farming. However, these studies were conducted in March and May of 2018, well befor began reporting an increase in problems on MTurk. In addition, we excluded data from accounts wi addresses or IP addresses from outside the U.S.

More Details

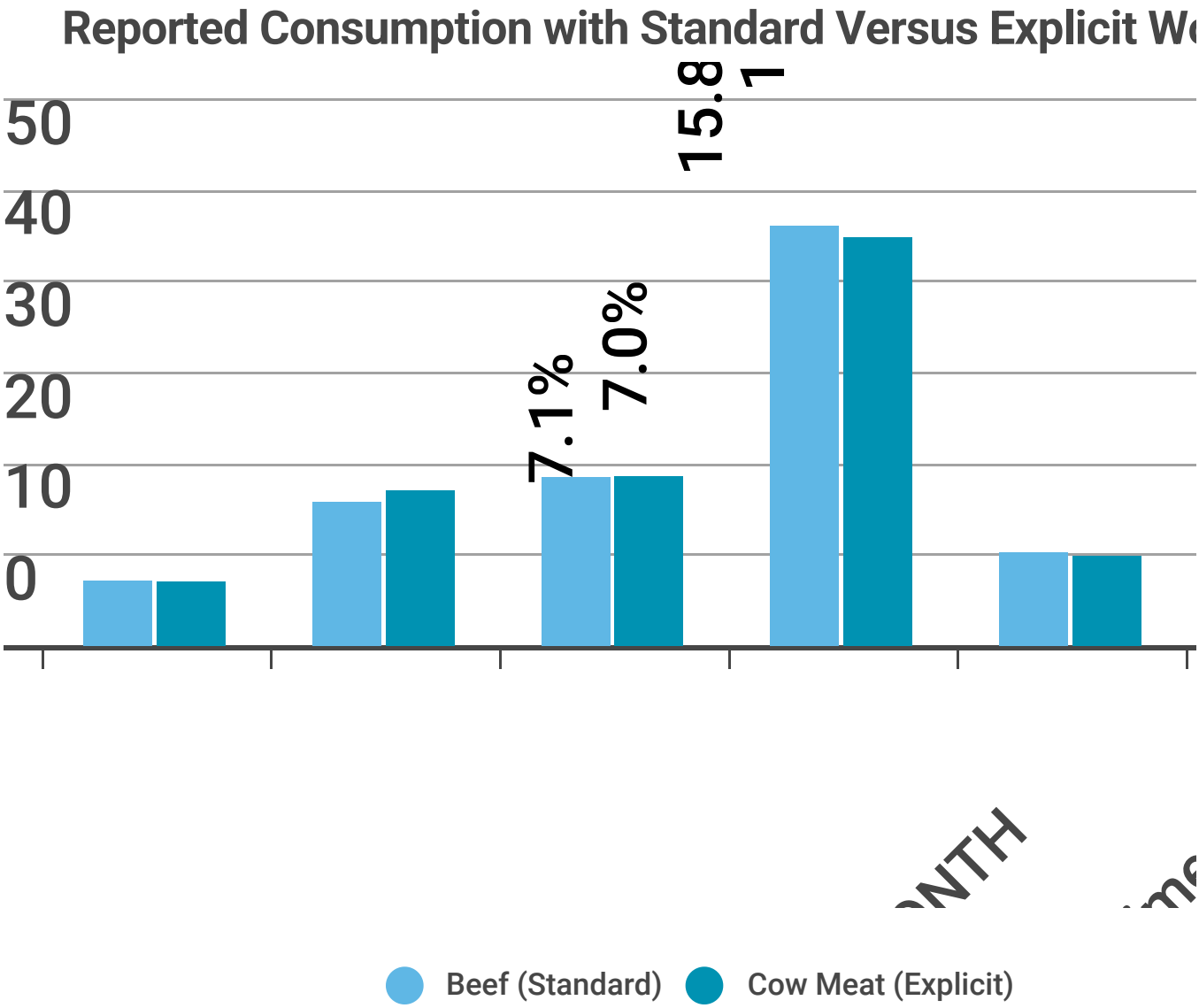
For details of the measures, power analyses, analysis plans, and more, please see the **pre-registratio** for both studies on the Open Science Framework. In addition, the Study 2 document contains more our concerns with the specific questions used in Study 1, as discussed above.

Study 1

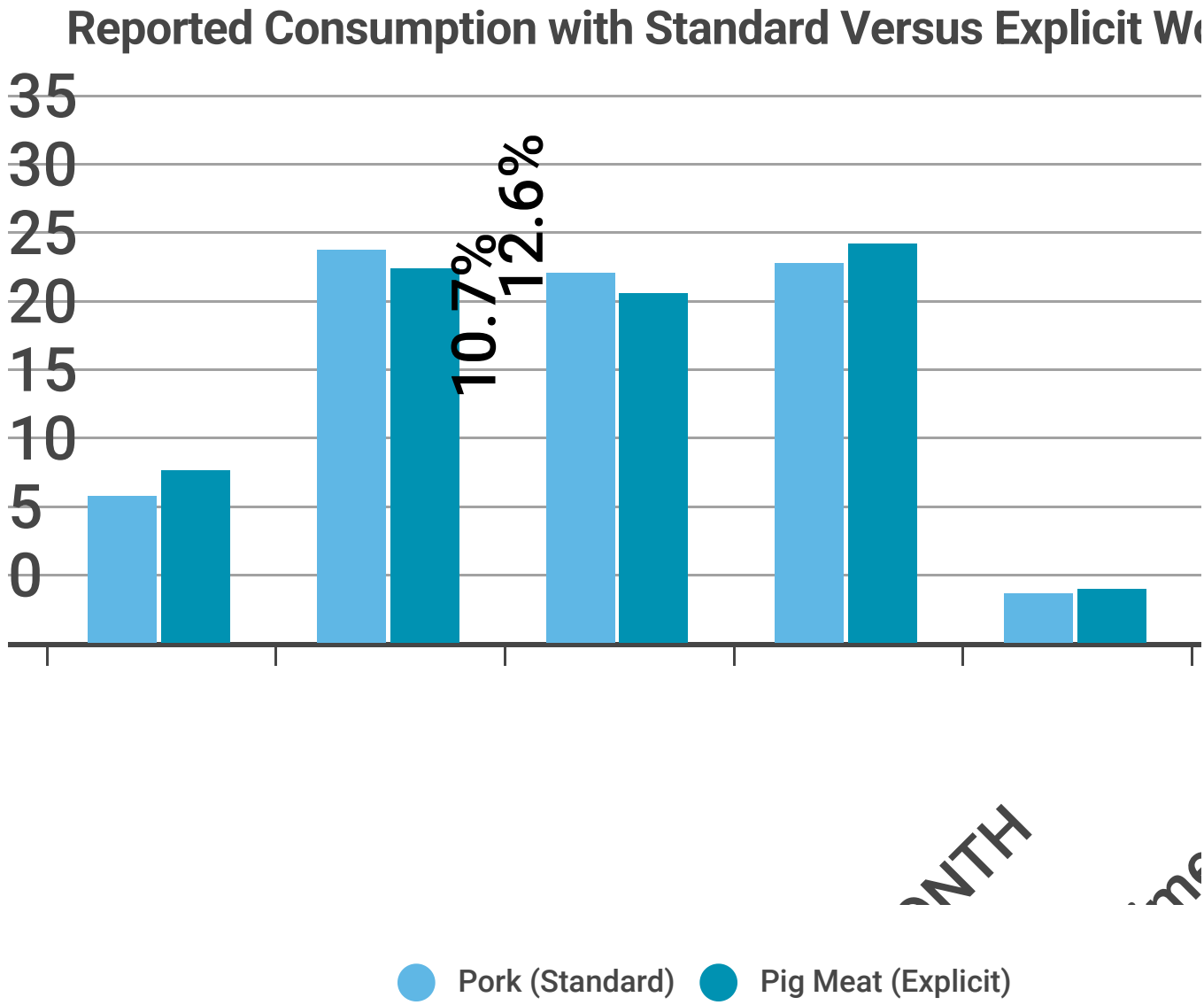
- Final sample: *n* = 775 Mechanical Turk participants with approval rating greater than 90% (after duplicates and 20 located outside the U.S.)
- Of the participants in the standard wording condition, 89.9% said they have eaten *beef* in the p proportion did not significantly differ from the 87.7% of participants in the explicit wording con they have eaten *cow* in the past year, χ^2 (775) = 0.91, *p* = .34.
- Of the participants in the standard wording condition, 85.1% said they have eaten *pork* in the pa proportion did not significantly differ from the 80.2% of participants in the explicit wording cor they have eaten *pig* in the past year, χ^2 (775) = 3.22, *p* = .07.
- Mean responses to the 5-point attitude item ("It is important to me that animals used for food a for") were quite high, above the *agree* scale anchor. There was no difference between the stanc = 4.09, *SD* = 0.89) and explicit wording (*M* = 4.10, *SD* = 0.96) conditions, *t*(773) = -0.17, *p* = .87.
- The differences observed in this study were in the expected direction and close to significant fo inspired us to run Study 2, but because those results didn't replicate, those small differences sh interpreted as meaningful.

Study 2

- Final sample: *n* = 799 Mechanical Turk participants with approval rating greater than 90% (after duplicates and 22 located outside the U.S.)
- There was no significant difference in participants' reported consumption of *beef* (standard wo *cow meat* (explicit wording), as determined by ordinal regression, Wald χ^2 = 0.08, *p* = .78. The p condition were:



- There was no significant difference in participants' reported consumption of *pork* (standard wo *pig meat* (explicit wording), as determined by ordinal regression, Wald $\chi^2 = 0.03$, $p = .86$. The p condition were:



- Mean responses to the 7-point attitude item ("Farm animals deserve the same consideration as animals, even if it means that meat costs more") did not significantly differ between the standa 4.60, *SD* = 1.62) and explicit wording (*M* = 4.67, *SD* = 1.65) conditions, $t(797) = -0.56$, $p = .58$.

Meet the Author: Jo Anderson

Jo Anderson is an advocate for animals and empirical research. She has many years of experience with a wide range of social science research methods and topics, as well as advanced training in statistical analysis. Jo became Faunalytics' Research Director in 2017 and since then has led and supervised studies of attitudes and behavior pertaining to

animals and veganism, advocate retention, donation decision-making, and many other topics. Jo has a PhD in social psychology from the University of Waterloo and completed a two-year postdoctoral fellowship at Cornell University. Jo's spare-time interests include sewing, reading, finding accidentally-vegan junk food, doting over cats, and being generally indoorsy.

Citations:

Anderson, J. (2018). *Pork or Pig? Beef or Cow? Implications for Advocacy and Research.* Faunalytics. https://faunalytics.org/pork-or-pig-beef-or-cow-implications-for-advocacy-and-research/

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2 Comments

Cathy Ji ▾

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Tom_Billesley

5 years ago

Is it really euphemism?
Anglo-Saxons were conquered by the Norman French in 1066. After that, they were the subordinate peasants who looked after the domesticated animals they named cow, pig, and sheep, whereas their new overlords had the luxury of a regular diet of the meat that they named beef, pork and mutton (French boeuf, porc and mouton). Same with the game animal deer, venison (French venaison). It reflects the feudal society of Norman England.

0 0 Reply

C

CherryBerry

7 years ago

Meat eaters I know don't seem to have qualms with the purchase or consumption of chickens, turkeys, or lambs (always labeled as "lamb" in my country regardless of age of the sheep), so it does make sense to me that the usage of cow over "beef" and similar didn't cause of great of a change as expected.

Though it's commonly discussed (and for good reason), I don't think there's as much of a psychological detachment from meat and animals among meat eaters as previously believed. This is likely the case where deer hunting becomes exceptionally popular at certain parts of the year in the USA.

Very recently , while I was grocery shopping I passed a shelf of promoted items all from a seemingly popular brand called epic. Every product from the brand was from an animal, and it followed the standard labeling of "beef", "lamb", "pork", "salmon" etc. On nearly item there was either a photo or a photorealistic illustration of the animal that had to be slaughtered or utilized to make the food product. I took the time to observe the packaging and word usage and it seems to me that actually the easier it is associate the purchasable food product with the animal , the more it's associated with being "high quality" or "fresh". Differing opinions in what is ethical instead of ignoring what is considered unethical is likely what drives the sale of

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GREATER REACTION.

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